

Sleep Hygiene

Practical tips for better sleep

Recommendation	Why / how
Maintain a consistent schedule	Go to bed and get up at consistent times, including weekends. Regularity strengthens your ability to fall asleep and stay asleep.
Nap early and keep naps short	Limit naps to 20–30 minutes, in the early afternoon. Avoid long naps (90 minutes or more). If you have sleep difficulties, avoid napping altogether.
Limit caffeine after lunch	Caffeine can remain active in the body for 6 hours or more (coffee, tea, energy drinks, chocolate).
Limit alcohol	Although initially sedating, alcohol harms sleep architecture: it reduces sleep quality and increases nighttime awakenings.
Avoid nicotine close to bedtime	Nicotine is a stimulant that can interfere with falling asleep.
Be active during the day	Physical activity helps manage stress and makes it easier to fall asleep. However, avoid moderate-to-intense exercise in the 3 hours before bedtime.
Get bright light in the morning	Morning light helps synchronize your biological clock.
Keep the bedroom dark, quiet, and cool	Ideal temperature between 15.6 and 19.4 °C (60–67 °F); nighttime noise below 40 dB. If needed: blackout curtains, an eye mask, earplugs, or white noise.
Don't check the time at night	Remove bright alarm clocks from the bedroom and avoid checking the time (clock, watch, phone): it increases arousal and prolongs wakefulness.
Avoid meals close to bedtime	Aim to eat supper 1.5 to 2 hours before bedtime.
Avoid screens before bedtime	Bright light from screens (computer, tablet, phone), especially blue light, sends an alerting signal to the brain and delays the circadian rhythm.

If sleep doesn't come...

If you can't fall asleep after what feels like about **20 minutes** (without checking the time!), get up, go to a dark, quiet place, and do a non-stimulating activity (light reading, slow breathing) until sleepiness returns. Then go back to bed.

iPhone tip: dim your screen in the evening

These accessibility settings make the screen much less stimulating at night:

1. Red color filter	Settings > Accessibility > Display & Text Size > Color Filters: turn on, choose Color Tint , then slide intensity and hue fully toward red. Red light disrupts the circadian rhythm far less than blue light.
2. Reduce White Point	Settings > Accessibility > Display & Text Size > Reduce White Point: turn on and adjust the slider (e.g., 80–90%) to lower brightness below the screen's normal minimum.
3. Quick toggle (triple-click)	Settings > Accessibility > Accessibility Shortcut: check Color Filters and Reduce White Point . A triple-click of the side button then turns them on or off in a second, every evening.
4. Scheduled automation	In the Shortcuts app > Automation > + > Time of Day (e.g., 8 PM, daily, "Run Immediately"): add the actions Set Color Filters (turn on) and Set White Point (turn on). Your iPhone then switches automatically to a dim red mode every evening — this red filter is more effective than True Tone or Night Shift. Besides reducing blue light, the screen becomes less "interesting": dull colors make content less appealing, which helps you disconnect from your phone at night. A second automation in the morning can turn them off.

Key takeaway: sleep hygiene is a cornerstone of preventing sleep problems, but it is generally **not enough on its own to treat established chronic insomnia**. In that case, cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia (CBT-I) is the reference treatment: it combines these measures with sleep restriction, stimulus control, cognitive restructuring, and relaxation techniques. Talk to your physician if your sleep difficulties persist.

Patient information document — does not replace personalized medical advice.

Sources: New England Journal of Medicine; NCCN; National Sleep Foundation; WHO; AASM.